



*Huge mouth for gulping
large amounts of tiny prey*

WOW!

Some whale sharks
may weigh 66,000 lb
(30,000 kg)—more
than a fully loaded
school bus.

*Each whale shark can
be identified from its
unique pattern of
white spots and stripes*

The whale shark is the biggest fish in the ocean.

MYSTERY SHARK

Basking and whale sharks have been known for centuries, but the megamouth shark was discovered as recently as 1976. No one knew it existed because it spends its days in the dark depths of the ocean, and comes up to the surface only at night. It follows the movements of the tiny zooplankton, which also migrate to the surface at night and go back into the depths by day. Luminous organs around the shark's big mouth may attract its prey in the darkness.

*Winglike pectoral
fins beat up and
down as it swims*

*Two long lobes help
channel plankton
into its mouth*

Gill slits

GIANT RAY

With its huge pectoral wings and two hornlike lobes, the manta ray is also known as the devil fish. It is the biggest of the rays, spanning up to 23 ft (7 m) from tip to tip of its big pectoral fins. The manta ray uses these like wings to "fly" through warm oceans in search of plankton. It feeds like a basking shark, swimming with its mouth open so food-rich water flows through its gills.

▲ FLYING FILTER FEEDER

*This view of a feeding manta
ray from below shows how its
big gill slits gape open as the
water flows through them.*